

THE MINORITY REPORT OF ROBOT LAW

ALGORITHMIC PREDICTION, PUBLIC TRUTH, AND THE DUTCH CHILDCARE BENEFITS SCANDAL

1 Introduction: from Robot Law to The Minority Report

In Dick's 1956 story *The Minority Report*, justice no longer waits for crime.¹ Three precognitive mutants, the “precogs”, foresee murders before they occur, allowing the police to arrest future perpetrators in advance. At the centre of this system stands Anderton, the founder and head of Precrime, who discovers that he himself has been predicted to commit murder. The philosophical force of the story lies not only in the apparent paradox of punishing people for acts they have not yet committed, but in the existence of the “minority report” a dissenting prediction among the precogs, which shows that the future is not singularly given. Here, prediction is not simple observation as it can alter the field of action it claims merely to describe.

Dick's plot turns on this performative logic. Anderton comes to see that the authority of Precrime depends on public confidence in its infallibility. If the system is exposed as capable of false prediction, its legitimacy collapses. The eventual choice to commit the predicted murder is therefore not merely personal, but institutional, the prediction helps to produce the future it announced. This makes the story a powerful prologue to contemporary algorithmic governance. Where Dick imagined mutants, contemporary states increasingly rely on data models, risk scores, and predictive infrastructures. These systems, too, may blur the boundary between identifying reality and shaping it.

This essay investigates the philosophical danger of what may be called “Robot Law” a legal or administrative order in which judgement is increasingly automated, predictive, and algorithmically mediated. Such a system promises neutrality, consistency, and emancipation from human prejudice. Yet this promise becomes dangerous when uncertain classifications, biased data, or administratively convenient proxies are treated as objective facts. The result is a “computer-says-no” mentality in which human judgement is displaced by algorithmic authority and affected persons are unable to contest the reasoning that governs them.

The central question is therefore whether a non-relativist notion of truth can survive in algorithmically mediated public systems, and what the Dutch childcare benefits scandal reveals about the political danger of treating predictive classifications as objective legal facts. It is argued that truth does not disappear once facts are shown to be mediated, assembled, or politically contested. On the contrary, mediation is the condition under which facts become publicly accountable. The scandal shows that Robot Law cannot be legitimate if it treats algorithmic outputs as self-evident matters of fact. Public truth requires matters of concern: the actors, infrastructures, proxies, exclusions, values, and consequences through which facts are produced must be made visible and contestable.

! [Blue](#) links to source saved on GitHub while [gray](#) links to bibliography and Dutch articles are translated to English.

¹ P. K. Dick (1956), [The Minority Report](#), happy read.

2 The controversy: Robot Law, prediction, and the benefits scandal

The central controversy through which the dangers of Robot Law become visible is the Dutch childcare benefits scandal, commonly known as the “Toeslagenaffaire”. This scandal concerned an administrative system in which parents receiving childcare benefits were wrongly treated as suspected fraudsters, often on the basis of rigid fraud-detection procedures, risk classifications, and bureaucratic assumptions. Its philosophical significance lies in the way suspicion was transformed into certainty. What appeared as neutral administrative classification became, in practice, a machinery through which families were made legible as fraudulent, indebted, and institutionally blameworthy. The affair did not emerge overnight. Early warnings in 2017 within the Tax Administration already indicated that the approach to fraud detection was disproportionate and, at times, unlawful.² These warnings were not adequately addressed. Instead, the system continued to operate within a political and administrative climate in which fraud prevention was prioritised over proportionality, care, and contestability.³ Thousands of parents were consequently labelled as fraudsters, often without sufficient evidence and without meaningful access to the information on which accusations were based. Case files were incomplete, heavily redacted, or entirely blacked out, making it almost impossible for affected individuals to understand or challenge the decisions imposed upon them.⁴

The injustice was intensified by practices of ethnic profiling, the use of second nationality as a possible risk indicator, and the internal awareness that the system could cause serious harm.⁵ What had been presented as a neutral administrative process increasingly revealed itself as a system of exclusion, producing bias under the appearance of objectivity. The consequences were not merely financial. Families faced debt, stress, stigma, institutional mistrust, and, in some cases, the removal of children from their homes. These “uithuisplaatsingen” mark one of the most troubling dimensions of the scandal, with 2,090 children displaced, showing that administrative classifications do not merely describe lives from a distance; they can reorganise the conditions under which lives are lived.⁶

Eventually, the controversy became impossible to contain. The former head of the Tax and Customs Administration described the affair as a “man-made disaster”.⁷ Political responsibility was demanded, and the Rutte III cabinet resigned.⁸ Yet the crisis did not end with political acknowledgement. Delayed compensation, missing records, and continued problems in information provision prolonged the suffering of affected families.⁹ The timeline of the scandal is therefore not simply a sequence of administrative failures; it is the gradual transformation of bureaucratic outputs into a public issue: a movement from apparent matters of fact to matters of profound concern.

As a warning against Robot Law, the case is decisive. If existing public institutions already struggle to make risk-based systems transparent, contestable, and responsive to human circumstances, then a fully automated legal order would magnify these dangers.

² NOS (2020a), *Top Tax and Customs officials warned as early as 2017 about 'reprehensible' approach to benefit parents*.

³ NOS (2019a), *Top Tax Authority officials ignored abuses for years*.

⁴ NOS (2019b), *Parents of blacked-out files: 'I still don't know what I did wrong'*.

⁵ NOS (2020b), *The Tax Authority checked people with dual nationality extra strictly*; and

NOS (2022a), *The Tax Administration already knew about ethnic profiling in the childcare benefits scandal in 2019*.

⁶ Algemeen Dagblad (2022), *2,090 children removed from home due to childcare benefits scandal, far more than expected*.

⁷ NOS (2020c), *Former head of the Tax and Customs Administration: benefits scandal is a man-made disaster*.

⁸ Trouw (2021), *The Rutte III cabinet falls over the benefits scandal*.

⁹ Algemeen Dagblad (2026), *Parents and children of childcare benefits scandal still suffer: 'I lost everything'*.

3 Latour and Dewey: from matters of fact to matters of concern

Latour's distinction between matters of fact and matters of concern provides the conceptual hinge between epistemology and politics.¹⁰ A matter of fact is usually presented as stable, objective, context-free, and oriented towards closure: it appears as something already settled, requiring only recognition. A matter of concern, by contrast, is not a weaker or less truthful object: it is an object understood through the actors, practices, institutions, instruments, affects, and consequences that gather around it. Here, public matters are precisely those issues that assemble different parties, passions, disagreements, and possible resolutions. Objects do not merely sit outside politics; they help produce the public spaces in which politics becomes possible.

Latour's discussion of Powell's 2003 presentation to the United Nations (UN) regarding the invasion of Iraq clarifies the danger of treating contested claims as if they were transparent facts. The point here is not that mediated facts are automatically false, but that facts become politically responsible only when the pathways through which they are assembled remain open to scrutiny.

This is why "making things public" does not mean adding subjective opinion to objective fact. It means bringing the Thing itself, with its attachments and consequences, into the assembly.¹¹ Political representation has two sides: A) The representation of legitimate speakers; and B) The representation of the issue at stake. A public is not complete merely because the right officials sit around the table. The object of concern must also be made present in a form that allows dispute, verification, and care.

For Dewey, a public emerges when the indirect consequences of actions extend beyond those immediately involved and require regulation, attention, and collective response. The public is not simply identical with society, nor does it arise from a separate "human" sphere opposed to nature. It forms around consequences.¹² In this sense, Dewey and Latour converge: politics begins when effects, infrastructures, and affected parties become visible enough to require organised concern.

This framework is crucial for Robot Law. In theory, an automated legal system might reduce bias, arbitrariness, and noise. Where a determinate set of legally relevant facts $F = [x, y, z]$ is established, and where a legal rule R is clear, a system could produce a verdict v :

$$R(F) = v, \text{ or if } x \wedge y \wedge z \rightarrow v \quad (1)$$

Such a model represents the ideal of deductive legal consistency; it promises to remove irrelevant influences such as race, class, gender, appearance, rhetorical skill, or unequal legal representation. This promise is not trivial, especially in legal systems where sentencing practices have historically harmed already disadvantaged groups (e.g., "three-strikes-and-your-out" in the United States).

Yet this ideal only works if x , y , and z are genuinely stable, verifiable, and legally relevant. In public controversies, the decisive question is often not how to apply a rule, but how the inputs were produced: who defined the categories, which measurements counted, which proxies were accepted, who was excluded, and which consequences followed. Robot Law becomes dangerous when it treats these constructed inputs as if they were unmediated facts. Therefore, the task is not to separate natural facts from human concerns, but to recognise one shared world that becomes politically visible through mediations, controversies, and consequences. The Kantian question then follows: if all judgement depends on conditions of intelligibility, how can truth remain possible without pretending to possess an unmediated view from nowhere?

¹⁰ B. Latour (2004), *Why Has Critique Run out of Steam? From Matters of Fact to Matters of Concern*, pp. 225–232; and B. Latour and P. Weibel (2005), *From Realpolitik to Dingpolitik in Making Things Public*, pp. 7–12.

¹¹ B. Latour (2004), *Why Has Critique Run out of Steam? From Matters of Fact to Matters of Concern*, pp. 232–237.

¹² J. Dewey (1927), *Chapter I: Search for the Public in The Public and its Problems*, pp. 11–34.

4 Kant: mediation, truth, and the limits of finite judgement

Kant offers a way to defend truth without returning to naïve objectivism. In *The Critique of Pure Reason*, knowledge is never a simple copying of the world as it exists independently of all experience.¹³ Space and time are not merely external containers in which things happen; they are forms of human intuition, structuring how objects can appear. Likewise, categories such as causality, substance, and unity are not optional interpretations added after perception; they are necessary conditions under which experience becomes intelligible at all.

This matters for the problem of Robot Law because it shows that mediation does not automatically imply relativism. The fact that knowledge is structured does not mean that truth is invented arbitrarily. On the contrary, shared conditions of experience make objective judgement possible. Kant therefore helps to avoid two extremes: the fantasy of direct, unmediated access to reality, and the sceptical claim that all truth collapses into perspective. Human judgement is finite, conditioned, and fallible, but not therefore meaningless.

Kantian reason also seeks unity. It attempts to organise experience into one coherent world rather than a chaos of disconnected impressions. Yet this unity is regulative rather than possessed as a complete overview. It guides inquiry, but it does not grant omniscience; this distinction is decisive for any philosophical defence of non-relativism. Here, there may be one reality, and some claims may answer to it better than others, but no finite subject occupies the standpoint from which the whole can be surveyed without mediation.

The rise of AI and speculation about technological singularity intensify this issue. The singularity names a hypothetical point at which AI surpasses human cognitive capacities and begins to improve itself recursively. Such a prospect may suggest that truth could be outsourced to machines. Yet even a vastly powerful algorithm would not remove the political question of which facts matter, which categories organise perception, and which consequences become publicly accountable.

¹³ I. Kant (1781), *The Critique of Pure Reason*.

5 Situated objectivity and automated inequality

The promise of Robot Law depends on a seductive image of objectivity: the idea that an automated system could rise above human partiality and produce decisions from nowhere. Haraway's account of situated knowledges directly challenges this image.¹⁴ Here, objectivity does not require the elimination of perspective; it requires the responsible acknowledgement of perspective. The "God trick" of seeing everything from nowhere is not a higher form of truth, but an irresponsible denial of the position from which knowledge is produced; only partial perspective promises objective vision, because only a situated claim can be held accountable for what it sees, what it fails to see, and what it makes possible.

This is crucial for algorithmic governance. A predictive model often appears more objective than a human official because it converts messy social reality into variables, correlations, thresholds, and scores. Yet this apparent neutrality conceals the fact that every model is positioned; it sees through selected data, chosen categories, institutional priorities, and historically produced patterns. The question is therefore not whether a system has a perspective, but whether that perspective is visible, contestable, and answerable to those affected by it.

Benjamin's analysis of automated racism provides a concrete example of this problem.¹⁵ In the healthcare algorithm, predicted healthcare cost was used as a proxy for medical need. On the surface, cost appears to be an administratively neutral variable. However, in practice black patients historically generated lower healthcare costs despite comparable or greater medical need, because less had been spent on their care. As a result, the algorithm underestimated their risk and need. The model did not need to use race explicitly in order to reproduce racial inequality; the bias entered through the proxy. This example clarifies the deeper danger of Robot Law. Algorithms are often not deductive machines that apply a legal rule to established facts. More commonly, they estimate probabilities:

$$P(Y_i = 1|X_i) = p_i \quad (2)$$

Here, i refers to an individual, X_i to a vector of observed features, Y_i to a future outcome, and p_i to the predicted probability of that outcome. Such a formula does not state that the individual will produce Y . It states that, given the model's data and assumptions, Y is predicted with probability p . The danger begins when institutions treat p as if it were a fact about the person.

Situated objectivity therefore avoids both naïve absolutism and relativism; it does not deny that some descriptions are better than others. Rather, it insists that better descriptions are richer, more accountable, and more responsive to the world they claim to describe. In this sense, a legitimate public use of algorithms would require not less mediation, but more visible mediation: exposed proxies, contestable classifications, accountable institutions, and affected publics capable of challenging the system's claim to Know.

¹⁴ D. Haraway (1988), *Situated Knowledges*, pp. 575–596.

¹⁵ R. Benjamin (2019), *Assessing risk, automating racism*, pp. 421–422.

6 From algorithmic fact to public concern: the Dutch benefits scandal

The benefits scandal is the central case through which the transformation from algorithmic fact to public concern becomes visible. The benefits system combined administrative data, fraud-detection priorities, risk classification, and harsh recovery rules. Parents were flagged, investigated, and, in many cases, forced to repay large sums of childcare allowance. The consequences included debt, family breakdown, psychological distress, loss of trust in government, and long-term harm to children (remarkably high deaths at 482).¹⁶ The info-graphic shows who and what assembled the scandal:



From a philosophical perspective, this reflects Latour’s claim that facts are assembled (see Chapter 3). What appeared as objective administrative truth was the outcome of decisions, classifications, thresholds, proxies, and institutional practices. A fraud label or risk flag may look like a neutral fact, but it depends on the categories through which a person is made visible. Benjamin’s analysis of automated racism (see Chapter 5) clarifies this mechanism: risk models do not simply discover risk but can reproduce inequality when their inputs and proxies reflect unequal histories. Zuboff’s account of surveillance capitalism places this within a broader political logic.¹⁷ Data extraction, prediction, and behavioural steering are not merely technical operations; they form infrastructures of power. Although the Dutch state is not a commercial platform, the childcare benefits scandal similarly shows how data systems can classify, anticipate, and discipline populations.

Investigations into the scandal found evidence of institutional racism, institutional bias, and violations of fundamental principles of the rule of law. Between 2004 and 2019, an estimated 26,000 parents and 70,000 children were harmed. Often minor mistakes, or misinformation by childcare agencies, were treated under a rigid fraud policy as grounds for full repayment. The affair was described by Amnesty as a human-rights violation,¹⁸ questioned in the European Parliament,¹⁹ criticised in relation to children’s rights by the UN, especially where debt contributed to displacement.²⁰

The system’s failure was therefore not only that it produced wrong outputs; it failed because its outputs were not sufficiently public in Latour’s sense. The affected people, categories, infrastructures, appeals, documents, assumptions, and consequences were not assembled into a contestable public issue until journalists, lawyers, courts, and parliamentary investigations forced them into visibility.

¹⁶ Trouw (2023), *State Secretary De Vries corrects her own figures on deceased children receiving benefits*.
¹⁷ S. Zuboff (2015), *Big other: surveillance capitalism and the prospects of an information civilization*, pp. 75–86.
¹⁸ Amnesty International (2021), *Benefits scandal is a human rights violation, says Amnesty International*.
¹⁹ NOS (2022b), *Benefits scandal discussed in Brussels: ‘This was not China, but the Netherlands’*.
²⁰ AJN Youth Doctors Netherlands (n.d.) *UN committee: The Netherlands must better safeguard children’s rights*.

7 Robot Law reconsidered: when can automation assist judgement?

The critique of Robot Law should not be mistaken for a rejection of all algorithmic assistance. A legal or administrative system without any automation would not automatically be more just. Human judgement is itself vulnerable to inconsistency, delay, prejudice, institutional pressure, and unequal access to representation. In limited contexts, automated systems may help identify relevant patterns, flag inconsistencies, detect administrative errors, or make decision criteria more explicit. Their potential value lies not in replacing judgement, but in supporting accountable judgement.

The decisive question is therefore not whether algorithms should ever be used, but under which conditions their use can remain legitimate. Automation becomes defensible only when it is subordinated to public contestability. Inputs must be open to challenge; proxies must be justified; model outputs must be explainable enough for meaningful scrutiny; and affected persons must retain the right to contest classifications. A risk score should never be treated as a fact about a person. Rather, it is a situated institutional claim, produced by particular data, assumptions, and purposes.

Deductive legal reasoning applies rules to established facts. Predictive systems, by contrast, estimate probabilities on the basis of past data. When these probabilities guide administrative or legal action, they may reshape the future they claim only to anticipate. An extreme example is the prediction algorithm the police use for juvenile delinquency in the Netherlands, this algorithm does not merely predict an outcome as its output may influence whether a young person is diverted to Halt or enters the criminal justice system. The latter matters because diversion can prevent a criminal record, while criminal prosecution can produce a “strike” that changes the person’s institutional future. Here, the classification may increase the very probability it claims merely to measure and thus the model becomes performative.²¹ Thus, a prediction can become an intervention. For that reason, algorithmic systems must distinguish clearly between evidence, suspicion, probability, and legal judgement.

The Dutch benefits scandal shows what happens when this distinction collapses. Administrative classifications acquired the force of truth before the affected parents could see, understand, or challenge the system that judged them. A legitimate system would require the opposite: transparency, appeal, proportionality, human responsibility, and institutional humility.

The image of the “minority report” is therefore not merely literary; it names a democratic requirement. Every automated decision system must preserve room for dissent, uncertainty, appeal, and revision. Robot Law becomes dangerous when it eliminates the minority report.

²¹ NU.nl (2025), *Police use prediction algorithm for juvenile delinquency*.

8 Conclusion: the critic as assembler, not debunker

The argument should not end by separating the world into two domains: 1) A natural world of facts; and 2) A human world of concerns. There is one shared world, but in public controversies this world appears through mediated, assembled, and politically charged truth claims. Matters of concern are therefore not weaker substitutes for matters of fact; they are the public form in which facts become accountable, contestable, and legitimate.

This also clarifies the qualified meaning of absolutism defended here. Here, absolutism cannot mean epistemic omnipotence, a view from nowhere, or a legal machine capable of possessing truth without mediation. It means ontological unity: there is one world, and some descriptions are more adequate, truthful, and responsible to that world than others. Truth remains necessary, but it becomes trustworthy only through practices that expose the conditions of its production.

Latour's account of critique is decisive here.²² The critic is not someone who merely debunks facts, unmasks everything as power, or destroys confidence in truth. Latour is better read as a stubborn realist: the task of critique is to assemble the mediations, actors, attachments, and consequences that make facts more real, not less. Critique should therefore not be understood as the destruction of truth claims, but as the careful reconstruction of the conditions under which truth claims can become public, responsible, and answerable.

This point is especially important in relation to Robot Law. A fully automated legal or administrative system may promise certainty, neutrality, and closure, but such closure is precisely what becomes dangerous when the mediations behind a judgement disappear from view (i.e., "Black Box" logic). The task is not to replace judgement with prediction, nor to replace facts with suspicion; the task is to preserve the conditions under which prediction, classification, and judgement remain open to contestation.

A just public order is therefore not one in which the machine's prediction becomes law, but one in which every prediction remains open to its minority report (i.e., critic).

Word count: 3,295

²² B. Latour (2004), *Why Has Critique Run out of Steam? From Matters of Fact to Matters of Concern*, pp. 232–248.

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